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THE TALIBAN DILEMMA

PARTISANS VERSUS CONCILIATORS

'For most Americans, the Soviet withdrawal is the victory. For our South Asian friends, it is only the first act in a much larger drama'.

Arnold L. Raphel, US Ambassador to Pakistan (1987–88)[1]

'Najib was an albatross around our necks, but we could not abandon him'.

Phillip Corwin, UN Information Officer in Kabul in April 1992[2]

'It seems the Indian Government has been formulating its Afghan policy without taking cognisance of the ground situation in Afghanistan. India needs to know a lot more about Afghanistan's present realities in order to be able to formulate a more realistic Afghan policy'.

Wakil Ahmed Muttawakil, member of the central shura of the Taliban, June 1996[3]

A failed escape

Najibullah was a lonely man on the morning of 17 April 1992. His one chance to escape from Kabul, at around 3 AM, had failed miserably.[4] Looking forward to joining his wife and daughters, who had left two weeks before for New Delhi,[5] he had planned a secret flight to India along with Benon Sevan, head of the UN's humanitarian aid division to Afghanistan. To prevent India-Pakistan bilateral relations from worsening further over Najibullah, Sevan had already taken